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Stanley Kay

Stanley Kay was born in New York City on March 20, 1924. During his long career in music, he has employed his drumming and managerial skills with an impressive list of artists, including Josephine Baker, Mel Torme and Buddy Rich. Stanley currently lends his expertise to promoting the big band Diva.

Stanley was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 18, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Clearwater Beach for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I am especially pleased to have Stanley Kay with me today.

SK: I'm especially pleased to be here. I'm especially pleased to be anywhere.

MR: Ta da boom.

SK: There you go.

MR: I'm trying to figure out how to introduce you, and you've done so many things I'll just call you a musician and a friend of musicians.

SK: Well I'm pleased that you said that, but I was a drummer, and there's a difference. I was very pleased and fortunate to have been able to fulfill my dreams and hopes because I started to play when I was about five years old, banging on pots and pans like most of us did. And the reason I got to do that was my sister was a very fine singer. She was like a child star. And she worked with Buddy Rich when he was Traps the Drum Wonder. And so for some reason when they took me to rehearsal to watch her, I would watch the drummer in the pit. And you never know why, Monk, you just don't know why. I can't tell you why, and you try to emulate what he did. You take your hands and — whether it's good or bad you don't know at the time at all. But all of a sudden you get kind of hooked on it when it comes in here and it comes in here. That's what you want to do. And I'm very happy that I did get to do it. And then what happened, I'd go home and listen to Chick Webb and Jimmie Lunceford and Duke Ellington and Count Basie and Woody, stay up and listen to the remote broadcasts at night you know. "From the Park Central Hotel and now the King of the Drums, Chick Webb." And he'd do a thing called "Let's Get Together." So I knew all the theme songs you know. And then, older, Benny Goodman's band, Gene Krupa was the innovator. And I listened to him and I said, "boy that's the greatest." And it's not that my sister said he wasn't. She said, "well I know somebody that's better than that." And I said, "who's better than Gene Krupa?" and I said, "and who is it?" "Buddy Rich." She said, "well he's playing at the Hickory House with a little band named Joe Marsala." That was his first band after he left vaudeville.

MR: And he tap danced too, didn't he?

SK: He tap danced. Yeah. He was known as Traps the Drum Wonder. And he was the second highest paid child star to Jackie Coogan. He was making about $1,500 a week. But when the decline of vaudeville, he had no job. And he worked on the WPA when they had the WPA. And putting on a wig and dancing and stuff like that see? And well anyway she told me Buddy Rich. So on Sunday afternoon on 52nd Street was a place called the Hickory House. And it was a round bar, it was a steak house. It was owned by a guy named Popkin. And my sister called Buddy and she paid the way for me. And I'm 14 years old. You could eat there, so at 14 you're okay you could go in. And jam sessions were about from three to six on Sunday in this big round circular bar. And it was Joe Marsala, his wife played harp, Adele Girard, his brother Marty Marsala played trumpet, Artie Shapiro played bass and Nat Jaffe played piano. And I walk in and I introduced myself. And he's 19 now, he was five years older than me. And I was 14. So he greeted me, but all the guys used to sit in from all the bands on this jam session. Like bands like Tiny Bradshaw and Andy Kirk's band, O'Neil Spencer was a wonderful drummer played with the John Kirby band. And he didn't play. And it was now getting towards like 5:30 and I'm like what am I doing here, because I have to come to have a steak or, you know, I wanted to hear this guy play. Supposed to be this genius, see? And he sat down and played the last thing. It was what we call a flag waver, it was called "Jim Jamp's Stump." And when I heard "Jim Jamp"— and I heard him play, I said that's it. My sister was right. That's the greatest thing I ever heard. And I just idolized him. And I followed him. Bunny Berigan, when he went, and before that he came down to my house to hear me play. And he didn't tell me but he told my sister, he said, "he can't play." And I cried. I really cried. I mean, whatever.

MR: This was about 1938?

SK: '38, yeah. And in fact he did the Old Gold Show from CBS with Artie Shaw. And Robert Benchley was the host. And I'd stand there, it was like a seven o'clock or six o'clock broadcast And Robert Benchley was the host and they'd open up with, they'd say, "would somebody wake up Benchley? Would somebody wake up Benchley? Would somebody, somebody, somebody, somebody, somebody, wake up Benchley? And he'd say, "ahhh, he's up." And Buddy'd play a drum fill and they played "Crazy Rhythm." And I used to wait that whole hour. I used to go every Sunday. And then I had to get home because Ellery Queen was on radio. So I went home to hear Ellery Queen. So that's how it all started. And actually, after he left Bunny Berigan, I read in the trades that Artie Shaw was looking for a drummer. Cliff Lehman was leaving. And I waited by the Lincoln Hotel in like the alleyway where like the stage door was, I waited for Artie Shaw.

"excuse me Mr. Shaw," I said, and he felt like talking, I don't know. He said, "what is it, young man?" I said, "well I read that you were looking for a drummer." Cliff Lehman was leaving. I said, "I know the greatest." And he said, "who is that?" And I said, "Buddy Rich." And he said, "he can't play." And a week later he joined the band. And in my little mind there I thought I got him the job. And then he went with Tommy and then I went with Shorty Sherock. That was the first band I really played — the first jazz band that I played in. And after, when I left Shorty and we disbanded, 1947, because I mean I would do anything Buddy asked me, I mean I'd go out and swim in the ocean and think I'm going to Europe if he asked me. I'd do anything he wanted. Didn't matter. So he asked me to join the band. He called me. And I joined the band at the Sherman Hotel in Chicago in 1947.

MR: Which band was this now? Shorty Sherock?

SK: Shorty Sherock was a great trumpet player. He played with Horace Heidt. But Nat Pierce, I got Nat Pierce the job in the band. All right? But after that Buddy called me. And the way I joined the band, I get into town and I go to his suite and he said the first set was seven o'clock, because you played for dancing then. And I remember all the guys that were in the band I could tell you their names. So he said, "go down and play the first set." He didn't take me down. So I walked up to the bandstand, and the guys are saying, "where are you going, kid?" And listen to this statement, "I'm the new drummer in the band." No, "I'm the drummer in the band." "What are you here to steal the drums?" Buddy didn't tell them he was hiring an assistant. That's how I started. They said, "well who are you? What are you doing here?" I said, "well I'm the drummer." "Something wrong with you? What does he do?" But he didn't tell them. So that's how we really started.

MR: Wow. Let me take you back for a moment. I have two questions. First of all you were a young boy during the depression?

SK: I'm not that old, no I was five years old.

MR: Okay, do you have any recollection of whether or not that had any effect on your family?

SK: No. We weren't rich but we ate. We could eat and pay rent. My father was a wonderful man, rest his soul. He was my pal. And my mother was too of course.

MR: What did your father do for a living?

SK: He was a shoe salesman.

MR: Okay, so as far as your recollection, nothing changed, I mean as a kid I guess you wouldn't—

SK: No I know we ate. I didn't know what was going down you know. My mother, being from a Jewish and a sort of kosher home, we could do whatever we wanted. She used to

remember, you saying that, because I'm not a gourmet but I love great restaurants, that's my thing. She would take noodles, which we thought was going to be spaghetti. She'd put ketchup on it and that was supposed to be like marinara sauce. I thought it was great then. But after I asked her, "what is that? What kind of food is that?" So it was fun. But I don't know. I really don't remember.

MR: Radio had such a big role at that time, didn't it?

SK: Um hum.

MR: With all those live broadcasts and all that.

SK: Yeah well that's where you learned. I mean I'd get in the bed, at one o'clock, I'd put my little radio on, of course they were doing remotes from all over the place. You know, "high on the top of the Astor roof we're presenting Tommy Dorsey." Or, "Horace Heidt and his Musical Knights." Whatever they did. So, no, I loved it, and I love it today. I talk with the same enthusiasm as I did back then. Because music is, I'm very grateful for it. It has been very good for me, I've gotten to go all over the world because of music. I mean I know people that haven't been over to Jersey yet and have been in New York. I've been all over the place. So I'm happy.

MR: Yeah. How did it work with being in with Buddy Rich. He played part of the time?

SK: No. What it was, see it's a fallacy. People write what they think. They think that I drove the bus, which I never did because I couldn't ride a bicycle. I didn't drive any bus. I could drive a car. What it was is I was his assistant so to speak. In other words they said that I went and played the charts and he sat when we got a new chart, that he sat in front listening to me play. That's not true. Because when he was with Tommy, Harry James, Artie Shaw, there was no assistant drummer. He could play it the first time he heard it. So all I did was if he wanted to sing, I played. And when we did a dance if he felt like doing that, he did it. When we played the Paramount Theater or the Strand or all those theaters we played all over, the Apollo and the Howard in Washington and the Regal in Chicago, I played the acts when he wanted me to do it. But then it was interesting because playing with your idol, like if he would compliment me, if he would say, "boy you really sounded good," I didn't want to hear that because I didn't believe it. See? So I'd say, "oh the bus is leaving at four o'clock." I didn't want to hear I play good. I don't want to hear that. Because you know, you're playing with your idol. It was better for me when I joined like Frankie Laine for six years and Patti Page and Josephine Baker. But we toured with Josephine. It was Sweets Edison, Buddy and myself. And Sherrie [Maricle] will tell you, with the band, that sometimes — she's a fabulous drummer and a great leader and a brilliant musician, far better than I ever was, she's far better than I ever was, really, that's truthful. She's a musician. She's a composer, she's a doctor of music you know. But they

contributed a lot to jazz." And everybody in the audience in listening. They've got their ears up. And they says, "you don't know this, but he was the original drummer of 'How Much is that Doggie in the Window' with Patti Page." And I was.

MR: Wow. You played that waltz thing, huh?

SK: Yeah. And I couldn't count four after. We played so many waltzes I forgot how to count four. But, you know, and we laughed. I mean we had good studio musicians — Chris Griffin and Andy Paretti and good players. And we all thought it was hysterical. It sold two million records.

MR: I was going to ask, at the time, you guys probably thought, oh come on.

SK: Yeah but you know what? I think George Duvivier, the great George Duvivier was on that. And he was so dedicated that if he played one note, he'd go in to listen to it to see if the note was in tune. He was that kind of guy. That dedicated. And I was in awe of all these guys. Playing with Chris Griffin was the lead player with Benny Goodman, you know. I was in awe. Jack Lesberg was a bass player. I just told — in fact when I joined the band we had a bass player that played with Russ Morgan's band, or Carl Hoff. And he wasn't really a conception player. You know he could play. And when Jack Lesberg came in the band I grew a hundred times, playing with a good bass player. You know it helped me. And that's all I wanted to do, I just wanted to play.

MR: What was it like traveling on the road at that time?

SK: Great. You'd go into towns that you'd never been to. You know, like our band, we'll stay in Storage Roach Motel and then we'll stay at the Trump Plaza and they've all got phones in their rooms and then they complain. I says, "listen, keep this in your mind where we just stayed so when we stay at the Roach Motel, remember where we stayed and be happy." But all the bands did it. Basie, Woody, Duke. You get the good and you get the bad. But we love to do what we do.

MR: Was your family surprised at the direction your career took?

SK: No. Because they knew that's what I wanted to do. That's all I wanted to do. I never wanted to do anything else. I'm not proud of it. And people shouldn't do what I'm saying, but I didn't graduate high school because I spent all my time in the Paramount Theater when the new bands were coming. It was like empty in the school. I was one. I was the leader of empty. And it was an interesting thing because when we went to the Paramount Theater, we gave one guy 55 cents in the morning. And it was, you had Don Baker at the organ, a sing-a-long, a bouncing ball, Fox Movietone News, the movie and then the band. And it could be Tommy and Frank Sinatra and the Nicholas Brothers or Charlie Barnet. And I'd sit there and say when am I going to do that? When am I going to do that? And the first time I did it with Buddy Rich, when the pit went up, I looked down

and saw where I sat. I looked right there, and I went like this, I says thank you. I says I made it.

MR: Oh you were looking out to where you used to sit in the audience.

SK: Where I used to sit, yeah. I know where I used to sit. I wanted to look over the band, so I could see what everybody's doing. And then when we played it, you know, when I got to do it the first time, it was like — I know a lot of baseball players. I'm an entertainment director of the New York Yankees also. And I've been with Mr. Steinbrenner for a lot of years. And I ask ball players, I ask like certain guys, I say, "how did you feel when you — your first major league game, you went to the major leagues? How did you feel?" And they would tell me — well I felt the same like they did. Because that's the major league. When you're playing with a big name band like Buddy, that's the major league. And we had great guys in it. I mean I talked to Johnny Mandel the other day. Johnny played bass trumpet in a band, Mandel. And I'd say, "John," I said, "you're Johnny Mandel," I says, "you know how happy I am that you wrote 'The Shadow of Your Smile' and 'Emily' and did all that on the Army show." You know which one. Help me someone.

MR: The Dewitt Show?

SK: The thing with "Mash."

MR: Oh right.

SK: And we talk, and I'm happy for those guys, and Zoot and Al Cohn and Sweets. Sweets was my idol. Harry Edison. You know from the Basie band. And it meant a lot to me. I once said, recently, Snooky Young came in. You know who he is?

MR: Sure.

SK: And Snooky and I — he played for us when I managed the Hines Brothers. And I wrote their act and conducted. And I'm standing with Snooky and I said, "hey Snook," I said, "you know I can't believe I know you and you are my friend." He said, "what are you saying?" He said, "you were my boss with the Hines Brothers." Because I managed them. And I said, "no I was never your boss," I said, "we worked together. But you are Snooky Young. And I saw you play in the Lunceford band and I know you." He couldn't understand that.

MR: I know. Those guys, they don't think of themselves like we do.

SK: Yeah. Exactly. It's always, and the thing with our band, I feel when those guys like, rest their soul, like Sweets and Clark Terry and Tommy Newsom and they come and said, "boy that band sounds good." And that's what makes me go even further in my belief, which is almost total. But they won't tell you that because they're your friend. Because they played with the greats. And they're not going to tell you, and I know they're not, but they go, "Stanley," you know, "Sherrie." See they're secure. The ones that are not secure,

yeah they're playing, women, all right. Because they're threatened. See? When you're not threatened, you're secure. There's got to be room for everybody. See?

MR: Good statement. How did the business change during the war years?

SK: Well when the band thing was over, you know, I caught some of the good part of it. When the business changed they went into vocalists, which was great, because the vocalist still accompanied the bands. You know, Ella Fitzgerald, one of the greatest of all time, and I got to play with her. I subbed in Buddy Morrow's band. And I took the gig, I had three days off, because I loved the way Buddy played trombone and I wanted to hear her sing. So I played for three days. The business changed I think, and due respect, when the rock & roll, whatever the name of those groups, the Chandeliers, the Lamps the Trees, the I don't know the Beds. When they came in, that did it. You know they had this new thing. Because what they do, they don't really — they listen — in my opinion, and I don't argue with success or whoever you like. I thought Eminem was a candy.

MR: I did too.

SK: You know, but if the kids like that, that's their time. You know I can't say don't like it, you like it, like it. We didn't have all wonderful things in our time too. So it becomes opinion. What do you like? What do you like? And it changed because of that. Then the promoters concentrated on that. On making — no more dancing, that started it you know. And Buddy [Rich], toward later on, he wouldn't play for dancing. He had a concert band. He would not play for dancing later on. But that was his choice. But he was so phenomenal, I mean he would have been 82 on September 30th he would have been 82. And I really believe this, really in my heart. If he was alive today he would have played the same way that he did. He may have got a little more tired, but look out. I used to tell him, we'd talk. And you know you have your ups and downs financially. I'd have five dollars in my pocket and I'd give him two fifty and I'd take two fifty and we'd take the train to Brooklyn. I'd stay over at his house sometimes. And I used to say to him you know, "God said — Zen, Buddah, whoever you believe in — is going to put someone on this earth to do this thing better than anyone else, and he chose you and you don't know what to do with it." Because of his complexities.

MR: Besides the energy and the speed he had in his hands, what was so great about his musicianship for you?

SK: Well his musical taste. See he played different ways for different people but his band was his band. He was going to do his thing. But he was Count Basie's favorite drummer and Jo Jones and Shadow Wilson were great. For me it wasn't the speed. Because you can get rudimental drummers out there that play in a marching band, they can go [scats]. It was his taste and the daring, exciting way he played to make fills. He would make drum fills

never practice, never had drumsticks in his house, he'd play on anybody's set of drums, at any time. You could wake him up at four in the morning and go [claps] and he'd be there today. He could just do it. I mean I've seen him come up through — he had slipped discs. And I seen him come up to the drums like the Hunchback of Notre Dame, he'd come up like this and sit down. It was like mind over matter. He forgot that. Or wisdom teeth being pulled. He could just do that. And the great story is when he broke his arm. You know he played with one hand. You know that don't you?

MR: Yeah, I heard something about that.

SK: Well I know, you want to hear how it happened?

MR: Yeah.

SK: Okay we are in Ohio. And I'd sit next to him on the bus see. Right here. And then he had the outside, I had the window. But you know you're doing 200 miles and you've got to —ah you're disturbing me. I said, "wait a minute, you don't want me to breathe?" Because I'd get into that with him. So we get into a town at eight in the morning, in Ohio. Columbus, Ohio. He said, "come on, let's go to a movie." He loved movies. Cowboy movies, D movies, E movies, Z's, whatever they were. I said, "I'm not going to the movies today." I said, "I'm going to the gym instead and I'm playing handball." "I'm coming too," he said. And his brother came, Nicky. We're playing four wall handball. I don't want to be the handball champ, I just want to hit the ball against the wall. But he's got to be the best and he's smashing it. But he ran into the wall like that. And he went ahh. So I said, "ah what? What are you singing?" So he said, "I think — my arm." I said well go down and get a steam" they had a steam room there, a sauna, "and your brother and I will finish the game." He comes back up. "My arm doesn't feel good." So I take him to the doctor. They put one of these slings on it, right? And we're rooming together. And ah, at four in the morning, "my arm," like a hypochondriac. So I says, "hey B listen," I was straw boss of the band. "I got to get things going at seven in the morning. I can't hear this all night." But I said, "I'll tell you something, if you die, I promise you I'll make you a nice funeral. Let me get a little rest here." I said, "I mess things up and then you're going to get on me, 'you don't know what you're doing,' and I'm not going for that." So anyway, we got three days left then we're going to New York. We've got two days and we open at the Apollo Theater. He gets to New York and the arm was broken in three places. And he had like a brown suit, a brown sling, a gray suit, a gray –. He liked all that coordination. We opened the Apollo Theater — we were one of the favorites, and one of the few white bands that could do it. They liked Charlie Barnet and us. And he was a big favorite. So Tiny Kahn wrote a chart for us on the "Carioca." I remember. See but he sits very high, and the layman don't know if he's playing with one hand or two

act and I played. They see the big sling. Clark Terry told me, he said he was there and the word went out that Buddy's arm is not broken, he wants to show he can play with one hand. But it was broken. So we played there a week, then we go into the Paramount Theater downtown and the managing director of the Paramount, Bob Whiteman, came up. And he said, "the rumor is that your arm is not broken but there's a sensation — keep it in the sling." If it's not broken we could play the Paramount. See and he never liked two bass drums. He said, "Louie's jive with it. It's tough enough to play one." But they were good friends, don't get me wrong. He said, "call Ludwig. Send for two bass drums." So he could get anything he wants. So two bass drums come in. Never practiced it, sat on a stool, no other drums around him, and just played the two bass drums like a tap dancer. With the arm broken and everything. But here's the uncanny part of this whole thing. Now if you're an athlete, and your arm is, you know a pitcher or — but your arm is sprained, you don't throw the ball fast like the 90 mile an hour fast ball, right? You work it in. The next day he took the thing off he played like it was never broken. And I just said I don't know where that's coming from. And that's what he did. That's what he did. And another story, see he always felt the guys were putting him down because he couldn't read music. I mean he didn't know a note. He was like Erroll Garner. Wherever the hands went was the key. So they wrote a book for him, *The Drum Book*, Henry Aller. And it sold like a hundred thousand copies, but everybody wanted the dexterity that Buddy had. So he decides to want to read. And he gets the drum pad. And his band boy was a drummer. You know, an amateur but he could read some. So Buddy opens the book and it's page one, and he's got to play four quarter notes and — two bars of four quarter and two bars of eighth notes. He could play the four quarter notes, he's going right, left, right, left, right. But he can't play one and two and, see he doesn't understand that. And he was impatient. So after four or five minutes he took the book and threw it up against the wall, he said the book is wrong. That was him. And then the other part, a kid comes, he did a one day theater. He was very quick, quick humor. He was walking out on stage. Buddy was in a good mood, and the kid comes with a book like this, and he's on page 110. Difficult. Not page one, page 110. And he goes, "Mr. Rich," he says, "I'm a big fan of yours." He says, "excuse me," he says, "I'm having trouble with this passage." And he goes "can you tell me how to play that?" He says, "just like it's written, kid, just like it's written" and walked away from him. So that was the humor.

MR: He was never at a loss, was he?

SK: No, no, he was quick. In fact at the Paramount Theater when he was in a good mood it was high, and there was a backdrop here, and he was shooting me with water pistols. He'd shoot me from the back. And I'm playing there, to the audience, and I'm trying to

duck and they thought I was spastic. They thought, I'm doing this. I don't want to get hit in the back. And he's laughing and I'm doing it.

MR: Oh God. He was quite a practical joker.

SK: Oh yeah, oh forget it. He threw a pie in Mel Torme's face while he was singing.

MR: Really?

SK: Oh yeah. We were playing at our club, Buddy's club that I ran, and it was Mel's birthday. And he said, "I'm getting a pie and I'm going to throw it in Mel's face while he's singing "Blue Moon." And I said, "Buddy, it's a new club, you know, people are going to get whip cream on their suits, they're going to sue us." So I said, "don't do it, Buddy, please don't, just don't do it." So I didn't trust him that he wasn't going to do it. So I told the band boy later, I said, "if you see a cake coming out, if I'm over on the telephone, get me right away." But the phone rang and I was there. But Buddy said, "I'm doing it." And Mel was singing "Blue Moon/I saw you standing—" And the whole pie went right in his face, got on all the customers, Mel is screaming and the customers want their money back because he didn't finish the act, he had four songs to go. And Mel is crying because he idolized Buddy. And, "what are you doing." So I go to Buddy, I said, "Buddy, listen, I asked you not to do that with the suing – the cleaning bills." I said, "why did you do that?" He said, "oh yeah, from now on no more fun." That was his answer. So what are you going to say after, no more fun. But he liked to do that stuff.

MR: He seemed to have a — on one hand be really filled with fun and everything, and he had a temper too, is that right?

SK: Oh yeah. Well I always say, people want me to write a book about it but I believe here the man's gone, he can't defend himself or whatever is what I would say. But see he did that black belt stuff. He wasn't a black belt, he was an honorary black belt. He could break the boards and everybody got afraid. He'd go HUH and the boards broke, and they'd go, "don't play around with him," you know? So that was the part of his make-up.

MR: Yeah, it's his personality.

SK: Yeah that was his personality.

MR: They had some outstanding records. I know in college we used to just — we wore out "Channel One Suite." And all us guys, we'd just listen to that.

SK: Well I got Bill Reddy to write the "West Side Story" for him. I knew Bill from Vegas.

MR: It's fabulous.

SK: Yeah, absolutely. But I'm fortunate. And then it's because of him that — whether I could play or not — but I was his drummer, that means I was able to play. But that enabled me to learn, and I'm still learning, because you're never too old to learn, about how to handle or try to represent Sherrie and our band in the best way possible.

MR: You and John Levy are, I think, probably the great managers to have, because you went through it. You were musicians.

SK: Well and I always will be a musician. I will always be — I mean I managed the Hines Brothers for a long time, I did a show on Broadway. Maurice and I have been together 30 years. But if I could produce the biggest show on Broadway I'm a sideman. I will always be a musician. I would rather talk to guys and hear the story than talk to David Merrick. He doesn't interest me. I like to talk to the guys. And sometimes they can't drag me away because I'm laughing, talking the stories. That's where I come from, that's where I'll always come from. It doesn't matter about money or anything. That is my love. That's what I want to do and I am so proud here, what Sherrie, the reaction to Sherrie and Nicki and Karolina and Anat. Because they are fine musicians. And they are as good as any of the guys playing. There's no difference. There's no difference. And they can prove it. They go out and do it. See? And maybe ten years from now when the women come in, they went, "well it's a woman, I don't know how she's playing." She can play. And that's what we're trying to accomplish and keep this thing together. And have you heard our big band?

MR: Yes I have. Fantastic.

SK: Yeah. I mean we just played, I mean the musicianship. See I will sit there every night and I critique. I watch certain things. They don't listen to me but it feels good to tell them what I think. "Get coffee. You. Go for coffee." Or, "get me a sandwich." "Get me a hairdresser." You heard stories about being late, this is it. Whereas I don't know where we were, and I get a call, we were at a rehearsal, I get this call from Sherrie. This is my partner, Sherrie is the backbone of this band. She's the reason I have a band. Sherrie. And, "what is it, what's the problem, you've got a problem?" "No, no. There's no hair dryer in the room, I can't dry my hair." So I says, "What am I? A beautician? What do you want from me?" "Well I've got to have a hair dryer and the maids won't bring it up. You've got to get me a hair dryer." So I run, there's beauty shop, and I run down to the beauty shop, "can I borrow a hair dryer?" "We don't let them out." So I said, "well I'll give you a deposit. I'll give you fifty bucks." "No we can't do it." I call her back. "See you don't do your job." "What do you mean I don't do my job? What do you want from me?" So she had to come down. Now, this is the excuse see, when we were late. She says, "not bad." We were at rehearsal, not the gig. Now how do you say to a guy, "well we're late because there's no hair dryers. The leader of the band didn't have a hair dryer." So that's the humor side. And the other humorous one was — am I talking too much?

MR: No.

SK: The other humorous — when we first had rehearsal, John LaBarbara, you know, played

when we picked out 15. That's nine years — we are going to tell them where it's at. We got 75 years of experience between the two of us, we know the rotten band leaders, we stayed in the worst hotels, we know there's alcoholics, we know the drugs, we know everything. There's nothing you could tell us we don't know. And my first trumpet player, our first trumpet player, raises her hand and she says, "oh yeah, and I'm pregnant." Well she wasn't, but that's the humor.

MR: You've got a whole new set of problems.

SK: Yeah, we stop them cold. We've got you now.

MR: Well you know, you should have learned. You worked with one drummer and had to deal with all his things, and now you've got a whole new set.

SK: Well she's a joy. Sherrie makes me proud. She is dedicated, she cares. And like I say she's the backbone of the band. She keeps it going. Her musicianship is superb, she's a fine arranger and a wonderful composer. And we're proud. It's difficult at times because like with the male band, if you lose a bass player you can get 20 guys to play. Our book is very difficult. And the ladies come out of North Texas State, Berklee, like little Karolina, and Anat Cohen, they're all musicians, studied. And it's difficult because you can't get, with due respect, we're not playing "In the Mood" in this band. I mean you know. I don't want to because you're not going to play it as good as Glenn Miller and you're not going to play "Sing Sing Sing" as good as Benny Goodman. And of course they're going to compare you to that. If you want to do it, that's fine. Whoever wants to do that, that's the way they do it. This is not the way we do it. In fact before we got her we played at Pace University. And Bill Holman came in with music that could reach from here down – we're on the eighth floor. And he conducted. But he came in with them killers. And the band just played it, and you'd beam. And Slide Hampton came in, a great trombone player, with things from space I think. They are first playing it up there. And then Tommy came in normal. Tommy Newsom. He came in "Close Your Eyes, George." You know, nice, easy. But they played it, and they played it well, and they played it with dedication. And you sit there and you kind of go wow, look at that.

MR: That's got to be really gratifying—

SK: It is.

MR: —to have these guys come in with those charts.

SK: It is. And they take it home if they need it, and they woodshed it, and they look at it, and they come in and they do it. And they do it with great compassion and great dedication. They don't just slough it off, you know, who cares. So that makes you proud.

MR: How has the business changed, promoting music from 50 years ago?

SK: Well it's sad to say, you know what we always say, jazz is our country's music. I'm sure

roll and the rap and then there's whatever country, and that's fine. But we get more respect, or most of the jazz players will tell you, in Europe and Japan. And I don't understand that. I don't understand that. Because it's a great art to play jazz. I don't know, you know, playing drums. And I love melodic things, and lyrical things, but doing this, I can't play "Stardust" on the drum I don't think. If I could I'd make a lot of money. But anyway you know what they do is they don't respect it. They don't respect. Oh I know what I was going to say, like I don't know how these people play jazz. I don't know how you can improvise. I don't know how you can do that, like play anything you want to play and it becomes a melodic, and it becomes a composition. Oh there's riffs, there's standard riffs that we play. But like Lester Young played that thing behind Billie Holiday on the CBS special, that's like one of the greatest melodic things I've ever heard. And it's gorgeous to do that. But how do you do that you see? You got a lot of lead trumpet players that couldn't play jazz. They could play great lead, like Conrad Gozzo and Bernie Glow and some of those guys, and I really think, we play enough high schools and colleges where they make a mistake. Because you go in and there's the young players, the high school player. "Who is your favorite saxophone?" They'll say John Coltrane. Right? Okay. Now they don't know John Coltrane played with Earl Bostic's band, played the blues, but he wanted to progress. "You know Johnny Hodges?" "No." "You know Ben Webster?" "No." "You know Sweets Edison?" "No." Well if you don't listen, how are you going to get to — if you don't go to kindergarten and high school, how are you going to get to there? But the teachers don't tell them. Sherrie will go in and say, "we're going to play the blues." "What's the blues?" And they'll read the chart, of course they play it every day. After four bars of improvisation they're done. They can't play one — after the fourth, the fifth bar, over. And you're looking at, where is this all going to come from, what we're trying to keep and preserve. I'm not a campaigner, but I'm just talking about honest truth. There's a truth to what we do, there's this truth to our music. I mean I love a marching band if it's good in the street, I mean I go to the symphony and watch the symphonies play. But why? Why? I mean outside of Basie's band, that's not talking the dance band, not Glenn Miller. Buddy Morrow's got an intact band. The rest of them, the Jimmy Dorsey band, the guys got the library to "Tangerine" and "Amapola," he comes and gets twelve guys. They don't know the difference. They say, "Tangerine," oh, it's the Jimmy Dorsey band. The Guy Lombardo band or whatever. The Harry James band. One guy, they come with the book, you know, "Sleepy Lagoon," "You Made Me Love You" and they play. We out there, we buy these things. Maybe, I don't know, Sherrie could correct me, twenty, thirty thousand dollars worth of arrangements. And we're always trying to play new. And we're always thinking of new

chart. Let's try this. And we don't play anybody else's chart. We won't play anybody else's. We play what we want to play. And we have it arranged the way we want it arranged and what we want to do you see.

MR: Yeah. You've got an identity then.

SK: Yeah. But it's challenging. It's challenging to them. And they don't sit bored. We try to get as many, like at least what we can. Once every two months put a new chart in. We've got four or five things right now we really haven't tried as much as we should. And Sherrie is great at it because — Dennis Mackrel wrote a wonderful chart for us on "In a Mellow Tone," you know, the great Count Basie drummer. And we lived with it for a while, and Sherrie made some changes, and still respected what he did and it's for the better. See? It's for the better, what we do.

MR: Yeah. Well Basie used to do that too with his charts, didn't he? He would like tinker with them to make them sound like Basie.

SK: Yeah. Well you know Neal brought in, Hefti, you know the story, "L'il Darlin.'" He went [scats]. And Basie said wait a minute, no, no, let's do it that way. And it worked you see. So you're always experimenting. You're always trying to play new and fresh and do things — we try to write things for our soloists that they will like to play. Because you've got to believe in what you're doing. I don't do it up there, they do it up there. But I will comment. If I hear something I'll discuss it. I'll tell Sherrie, you know I don't think this is right. Like see you come here. Now we know what kind of audience this is. This is basically predominantly a Dixieland crowd. Not that the musicianship is flawed. Guys like Ken Peplowski and Harry Allen and Bill Charlap, hey. But you've got to play to the audience. You know what they like. So instead of playing something there, you've got to come in there because — oh we know that, we know that. And they relate to it. And you have to kind of, it's like Basie. He knew the tempos, he was a master at that. And that's where you learn.

MR: Yeah. I didn't get to ask you about being a club owner. Was that something that—

SK: Disastrous.

MR: Disastrous? Was it hard?

SK: No, no. My first club I had was called Sam's Jazz Upstairs. It was over on top of a restaurant on 64th Street. And that was mine. And my first attraction was Dee Dee Bridgewater, I took her out of the Mel Lewis-Thad Jones band, two Franks, Frank Foster and Frank Wess, Roland Hanna, Ben Riley and a guy that played like that, I'll think of his name, the bass player. And I tried it for about a month and the money left me.

MR: Really?

SK: Oh yeah, yeah. Buddy's club. I really was not an owner. He had part ownership but two

called — well it was called Buddy's Place but the restaurant was Sam's Jazz Upstairs. Then the one on 33rd Street was a 400 seat club. And my first attraction was Buddy's big band, Carmen McRae and Nipsy Russell. Because I wanted to bring the Paramount Theater days in there. And unfortunately the guy that owned the place was a thief. You know he did tricks. But we had Joe Williams in there with the Thad Jones band, we had Woody's band in there. You know we had good stuff going on there. But the problem with me owning or even managing a club, if you talk in the club while they're playing, you're gone. I'd put you right out. I wouldn't allow it. Well the reason is if you're in Carnegie Hall and Mr. Rubenstein is playing or Mr. Horowitz, you're not talking. I mean if you want to whisper, but when you get loud, in a small club— Stan Getz was playing in there and some people at the table were talking and I'd go over. I'd say, "see this sign here" I mean this little card, the tent card. "What does it say? Refrain from talking." And you'd better pay attention there because if I come back again—" And they didn't want to listen. So, "see I'm in a good mood tonight, that's twice. The third time you're gone. Now I'm telling you." So they calmed down. And I went over to them, younger people, I said, "why did you come in here tonight?" You know, why did you come in here? "Well we're fans of Stan Getz." I said, "well see you're not doing yourself justice. You could have saved all this money, stay home, play his records, and yell, scream, do whatever you want." I said, "let me ask you something." They would understand that. I said, "what business are you in, if I may ask?" "The furniture business." I says, "is Saturday a big day for you? You make big sales on Saturday, don't you?" I said, "if I came over while you're taking a two thousand, three thousand dollar order and yell and scream and make noise, if it's going to distract you, you couldn't make the sale, right? It's the same thing. That's how they make their living. That's rude." You see? So therefore, with me, I mean if they talk when the band's playing, I'm a little — who am I going to hurt? But I go tell them, don't do that. Don't get up and dance, we're not a dance band. Go in the back. Go play records and do "Mama Loves Papa" or something. Go there and do it. Don't do it in here. But that's my honesty. And it's not that I — I don't try to offend anybody, I don't try to be rude, I say please, this is not what we do. We don't do this.

MR: Well someone paid you a compliment just today. They said that you never offer any B.S.

SK: No. Because you know what? You live with yourself. I put my head on the bed, I know what I said. And I'm not doing that. I know exactly what I said and if I don't like you I will be polite and say hello to you, but it's like I'm saying hello to the floor. I don't look at you. I go hello. Hello floor. Because I think that's honest. I wish everybody well. I hope they make a million and stay healthy, but if you disrespect any members of my band, and Sherrie will tell you, I'll go right after you. And one of the main stories, well

The door was open to everybody. If they didn't come, what do you want from me? They could be green, blue, pink, whatever it is. If you can play, that's all I ask for you to do is play. I don't look at your color, Sherrie doesn't look at your color. In other words you've got a baseball team and it's all white, and you get a black shortstop or Oriental, and they can't play shortstop, they throw the ball away, they do this, you're going to lose the game. We're not going to lose the game. We're going to give you the best we got. That's all I ask from my band. They don't have to like me. They don't have to love me. All I ask you to do is play. Give me an hour, and give Sherrie an hour of the best you've got. That's all I ask you to do. After that you don't have to talk to me if you don't want to. You don't have to. But we're paying you, and you don't have to accept a job. You don't like the money? You don't like this? You don't like traveling? Don't do it. But if you do it, do it, give me a hundred percent inside and give it to Sherrie. Because she gives a hundred percent. And that's what we ask for. I don't think that's unreasonable.

MR: Understandable. Very clear direction, yeah.

SK: Yeah. And we love everybody. We protect them, we help them in every possible way that we can. You know. And expect nothing back. I learned that. If you do something for someone, don't expect anything back. Do it because you want to do it.

MR: Yeah. How did you get hooked up with the Yankees?

SK: Actually it was through Buddy Rich. We played, it was a double header and brought the band up. Because we had just recorded a new record and I wanted the name on the scoreboard. So we played. And timing is everything, Monk. We went down after the playing, and the game is over, and the executive office is downstairs. And Buddy and I are sitting there. And I just happened to say to the guard, I said, "is Mr. Steinbrenner here?" He said, "he just went across the street to get his car" it was the executive parking lot. And I ran out. And I said, "excuse me Mr. Steinbrenner, I'm Buddy Rich's manager?" "Where is Buddy?" He loves music. He loves big bands. I said, "right here." He said, "you and Stanley are welcome at my Yankee Stadium any time you want." That was the end of it. A month later I get a call, Mr. Steinbrenner wants to see you. I said what does he want to sign me to play first base? What does he want to see me for? I don't know. So I go up, and I'm sitting at the big round table. He and his whole family, it was a co-ed school, it's a high school, Culver, in Indiana. So his daughter was graduating and they got a group called Firefall. I didn't know if it was Winterfall or Summerfall, or I didn't know, a fall season. I didn't know what that was. And he was paying them ten thousand, and they canceled. And now he's in a panic. I don't know from — so I called Ronnie Beltz, who was the biggest rock promoter in New York. I said, "hey Ronnie, ever heard of a group, Firefall?" He said, "yeah." I said, "where do they work?" He said, "I

Steinbrenner," I said, "somebody saw you coming." You know they charge you money, they don't make that kind of money. So who can you get? So I liked Blood, Sweat & Tears. They were on the way out, but you know, were still there. So I said I'll call the William Morris Agency, which I did, talked to the agent, and he says they're available. So I tell Mr. Steinbrenner. I said they're available. And he checks things out to see who likes them, you know, if his daughter accepts it. So I called the agent and says they don't want to do it. So I have to go back. He says, "you told me they're available." I says, "available doesn't mean they're going to do it." But I knew Bobby Colomby, the drummer. And I said I'll call Bobby myself, I'll beg him. So now the agent says okay. Same money, ten thousand. I bring the rider back. I never saw this kind of rider and I'm looking at the rider. Dom Perignon, Cristal, steaks, orange juice, fresh eggs, what. And I'm looking at it and I'm reading and I'm going — he says, "what's the matter with you?" I said, "I wouldn't do this. This is not professional." "Well you're going to give it to them anyway." You know. I said, "I don't like it." He said, "yeah I don't like it. Get me someone else." So I called the agent and I said no deal. "Well you gave me a verbal." I said, "how do you ask for all this, steaks and chicken and chicken under glass, in glass, whatever, what is that? I don't understand." I said, "Frank Sinatra doesn't ask for that." You know, what is it? Anyway we canceled them out. And then a month later he was doing, his wife was doing, right here in Tampa, Florida, he was doing something, that's the home office, for a hospital. And he said, "who could I get for the benefit" for like one of the Catholic hospitals. I said, "well I'll get you the Buddy Rich band for nothing." 'Cause I still managed them. But pay their way from California here to New Orleans, no money, and I'll get you Mel Torme. But Mel gets paid. So Mel got five thousand, and it was very successful. And from then on there he trusted me. And I've been doing it for him for fifteen years. And he'll say, like he gets nervous. If we're going to do something he'll say, "you screw this up one more time." And now I know him so I just call him George, you know, but in front of people Mr. Steinbrenner. I says, "George, listen. I screwed it up fourteen times, another time doesn't matter. Fifteen. It's good. That's my record. Fifteen screw ups you got me, the head screw up of your world here that I produce shows for." And it's been very good. He's been — you know he's got his things too but when I had a slight stroke he came to see me in the hospital three times, paid all my hospital bills, sent me to Florida to rehabilitate with the ball team, stayed at his hotel in a suite. And at that time, and Sherrie, really took care of me. She nursed me and took care of me, back to good health. I still have a little limp. Because I idolized Peg Leg Bates. I want to dance like him one day. But anyway I come with the rocker, and I'm going in where all the young guys are training, at the complex, all the young ball players.

You know, coming up from colleges. And they see I'm doing this, walking in there. So they're looking at me. I said, "don't worry, I'm not here to take your jobs."

MR: That's a good one. Well you've had an amazing life and I can tell it's going to keep going.

SK: I'm doing everything I can. It's what I love to do.

MR: Yeah. I congratulate you on the work that you're doing with the band.

SK: Well I congratulate my band, our band. Sometimes I say my — it's not mine it's our band, it's Sherrie's and my band. I congratulate them because without the product I could maneuver all day long, but without the product I would have nothing. We've got a good product. We've got a great product. And I'm just hoping that people realize it, and give us a chance. You know the thing is that I went to the former president and vice president of Lippit, Harvey Schiller, through the Yankees. This is Yankee Nets now they bought the band. And I called Harvey up and I said, "you know, you know all the sponsors, you know all the people," and I said, "you know you were with the Olympics. You've had women baseball teams, soccer teams, tennis team, golf team, archery, whatever. We're no different." See you've got to be careful how you say it, but Sherrie pointed it out to me, it's a good band or a great band. But then you have to say but they all happen to be women. You see? And you don't categorize it. But we can play up to anybody and prove it. There's no thing in music. And I would say if you can play you can play. If you can't play you can't play. And I know a lot of guys that can't play in my opinion you see. And also a lot of women. So that's the key. So we're — as American Express — I'm not hawking anything, I'm just telling you. And we're an educational group. We play high schools and colleges. And we can save four people a year, or three, from making drugs or get them interested in playing, and look up and see — see the women of our band only had the men to look up to, whether it was Buddy, Woody, Lester Young, you know. But wouldn't it be great to say I want to play drums like Sherrie. I want to play tenor like Anat Cohen. Who's your idol playing drums? Sherrie. Who's your idol? Anat Cohen. Who's yours? Karolina. You see? There's a whole world out there to try to get. And the reason I talk about the sponsorship, it's not that we're looking for their money, we're looking for them to put us on a tour where we are beneficial to what they do. How do we help your product? At the same time, how do you help us you see. So that's, and you mentioned John Levy. Well we just did a thing for Dress for Success. It's about women who are — you know the organization. Well when I first heard about it, I heard it on my machine, I thought they said dress for stress. So I said how do you do a benefit for stressful people? Is it clothes that stressful people wear? I didn't know what they were doing. So what we did, we honored all the greats, like Clora Bryant who played with the

And Jean Bach and Virginia Whips, our publicist, and Viola Smith, the drummer who played with Phil Spitalny. But we honored Nancy Wilson. And she gave us a great compliment. And I talked to John Levy, because you mentioned about John, and she said I've worked for 50 years and I've played with a lot of orchestras and this is one of the finest I ever worked with. So she wants to go on tour with us. And we got our first date in September of this year in Tanglewood. And I talked to John about it you see. And she said well Nancy wants to retire but she came back and told John, she said I want to go on tour with this band. You see?

MR: Wow. That's something.

SK: So it's Nancy Wilson. And I know John. See John played with George Shearing when I was with Patti Page. We played the Chicago Theater together. So I know John a long time. John is a good bass player. And so we talked. And I said, "hey John, listen, if the rhythm gets tired you and I will play. You get your bass, I'll get the drums." I said, "it's be like a dirge, like a funeral in New Orleans." And John told me something funny, John would say, "yeah." He said, "imagine the rhythm section and we're out there playing and there's eight people in front and we're playing eighty choruses and they said to John and 'you've got it.'" And John says, "got what?" He can't play anymore like they do. You know the rhythm section, like they get all — the brunt is on them. Everybody, four choruses they go and they go for a drink and [scats].

MR: I always feel sorry for them.

SK: Yeah the rhythm section, we get it. Just keep playing, they don't care. So but we've had a lot of fun.

MR: Well listen, thanks for spending this time with me.

SK: My pleasure. Thank you for asking me.

MR: All right.

SK: Thank you, I really appreciate it.

MR: Best of luck and continued success.

SK: Yeah, we hope we'll get to play down where you are one of these days.

MR: All right, terrific.

SK: Thank you.

MR: Thank you.

SK: Okay, thank you sir.